next, despite substantial contrary analysis within the US government.[210] Kissinger claimed to skeptical allies that he had received an intelligence report that the Indian cabinet had made such a decision.[211] Indian assurances, made directly and through the Soviet Union, as well as doubts about military feasibility, failed to dislodge this belief.[212]

Did India intend to take parts of West Pakistan? At the time, Haksar wrote to Jha that India had "no claims against the territory of West Pakistan." Moreover, he asserted that even though Pakistan-held Kashmir "legally belonged" to India, Delhi had said repeatedly that it would not "alter the status quo by force."[213] After the war, Haksar commented to Jha that the cabinet had not discussed the issue and Gandhi had not "made a statement even remotely resembling" the one in the CIA report that Kissinger had been citing as proof.[214]

India would not have had time for expanded operations on the western front. Even in 1967, when considering India-Pakistan war scenarios, Haksar had noted that whatever India's objective, it would have a "short space of time" before "the activisation of international pressure" to cease hostilities.[215] With the war underway in 1971, it was clear that they had a fortnight to complete operations. After that, Soviet patience would run out, even as pressure at the UN from China and the US—and pressure on China to intervene—would increase.[216] At the UN, Beijing indeed criticized Delhi and "[its] behind-the-scenes boss," Moscow. Gandhi wrote to Zhou, explaining the Indian position and indicating that, despite China's harsh words, India would continue to "seek China's friendship."[217]

The White House thought China was watching the American response closely. Kissinger told Nixon that, if Pakistan broke up, Beijing would conclude that the US is "just too weak" and it might "drop the whole idea" of engaging with Washington.[218] To impress China, Nixon authorized the dispatch of a naval task force into the Bay of Bengal.

When the Pakistani army was on the verge of surrendering in the east, Kissinger suggested to Huang Hua, China's permanent representative at the UN, that India needed to be "intimidated" to prevent it attacking West Pakistan. He urged a coordinated China-Pakistan-US effort to confront the India-Soviet action. Encouraging China to increase its military commitment, Kissinger passed along Nixon's message that if China "were to consider the situation on the Indian subcontinent a threat to its security,